Selected Excerpts from Erica Frantz, Authoritarianism: What Everyone Needs to Know

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Chapter 1: Introduction

Excerpt includes "What Are the Challenges in Understanding Authoritarian Politics?" and "What Is an Authoritarian Regime?" from Chapter 1.

What Are the Challenges in Understanding Authoritarian Politics?

Compared to democracies, we know very little about how politics works in authoritarian regimes. In the past, this was at least partially due to an underemphasis in the social science literature on authoritarian politics. Yet, while scholars have historically devoted less attention to studying authoritarian regimes than democracies, this has changed in recent years. In the last decade or so in particular, research devoted to authoritarian politics has expanded dramatically, likely because of awareness that authoritarian regimes are not going away any time soon. After all, authoritarian regimes still govern about a third of the world's countries today. And there are few indications that a major decline in authoritarianism is on the horizon.

Even with increased scholarly attention to authoritarian politics, however, our understanding of political dynamics in authoritarian regimes is likely to forever pale in comparison to what we know of behaviors in democracies. Authoritarian regimes are notoriously challenging to study. Internal politics in authoritarian contexts is often hidden from public view, the media are typically censored, reliable data hard to come by, and government-sponsored propaganda pervasive. Authoritarian regimes are difficult to study, in other words, precisely because they are authoritarian.

Take the example of Laos. Since 1975, the Lao People's Revolutionary Party (LPRP) has governed the country under one-party rule. Most major political decisions are made at the party congress, which is held every five years, and most political power lies in the hands of the LPRP Central Committee Executive Board. Beyond basic features of the Laotian political system such as these, however, many things about how politics works in Laos are unknown. The period leading up to the congress, for example, is one of "swirling rumour" due to the "excessive secrecy" that characterizes decision-making in Laos. Observers are left guessing what is likely to come. Most can assess the types of individuals apt to wield political influence in Laos, at least on paper, but how negotiations take place and what the balance of power is like among key actors and institutions are often cloudy and up for interpretation. Political secrecy in Laos makes information hard to obtain, a problem the tightly controlled media exacerbates. Public criticism of the government in all forms is prohibited. In 2014, for example, the government made it a criminal offense to criticize the ruling party online. The government owns most media outlets, and foreign journalists and international organizations must submit their reports to government officials for editing prior to publication. Gaining insight into the specifics of how politics works in Laos is without question a difficult task and one that inevitably involves speculation.

Though Laos is an extreme example, in most authoritarian regimes informal guidelines drive everyday operating procedures. This means that an examination of the written rules of the political game often reveals little about actual political practices, which are further

obscured by the preference for secrecy over transparency.

For observers, this can generate challenges answering even the most basic political questions about politics in an authoritarian regime, such as who the de facto leader is and who has the power to challenge him. (The vast majority of dictators have been male.) As an example, most observers saw Prime Minister Vladimir Putin as the leader of Russia while Dmitry Medvedev was president from 2008 to 2012. Others challenged this assertion, however, pointing to Medvedev's efforts to assert his independence from Putin while in office. Supporting this, Medvedev stated in 2009, "I am the leader of this state, I am the head of this state, and the division of power is based on this."

Making matters worse, the media typically face serious obstacles reporting on government behaviors in authoritarian regimes. The information that they do release is often biased and intentionally inaccurate, even about basic information such as economic growth rates.

Contrast this with the reality in most democracies. The identity of the leader is usually fairly obvious. Even in democracies that are flawed, policymaking and leadership choice are generally transparent. Both are typically the product of an observable process that follows clearly spelled out rules, occurring under the watchful eye of a relatively free media.

In sum, due to the very nature of authoritarian politics, authoritarian regimes create challenges for those interested in understanding them.

What Is an Authoritarian Regime?

There are a number of ways that scholars define an authoritarian regime. In this book, a *regime* is the "set of basic formal and informal rules that determine who influences the choice of leaders—including rules that identify the group from which leaders can be selected—and policies." A regime is *authoritarian* if the executive achieved power through undemocratic means, that is, any means besides direct relatively free and fair elections (e.g., Cuba under the Castro brothers); or if the executive achieved power via free and fair elections, but later changed the rules such that subsequent electoral competition (whether legislative or executive) was limited (e.g., Turkey under Recep Erdogan). In other words, in the operational definition of an authoritarian regime this book uses, the distinguishing factor separating authoritarian regimes from democratic ones is whether government selection occurs via free and fair elections.

This definition is minimalist. It does not integrate human rights violations or repressive acts, unless they pertain to the ability of the opposition to have a reasonable shot of competing in the electoral process. It says nothing about levels of wealth, economic openness, political stability, or state capacity. This definition is consistent, however, with the bulk of mainstream research on authoritarian politics, where democracies are regimes in which "those who govern are selected through contested elections" and authoritarian regimes are "not democracies."

Under this definition of an authoritarian regime, multiple leaders may come and go within the same authoritarian regime. China under the Chinese Communist Party exemplifies this well, as does Nicaragua under the Somoza family. At the same time, multiple authoritarian

regimes may come and go within the same authoritarian *spell* (or span of years). The experience of Cuba illustrates this. Cuba has been authoritarian since 1952, but two distinct authoritarian regimes have led it during this time period: the first under Batista (in power from 1952 to 1959) and the second under Castro and later his brother (in power from 1959 to the present). Chapter 2 discusses both of these distinctions and why they matter in greater detail.

Because definitions of authoritarian regimes occasionally differ across the literature, the book will make clear, where relevant, when specific theories conceive of authoritarianism differently and the impact such conceptualizations have on understandings of authoritarian politics.

Chapter 5: Authoritarian Regime Types

Excerpt includes the opening comparison, why regime type matters, the chapter's categorical typology, the three main regime types, their consequences, and the trend over time shown in Figure 5.1.

How Do Authoritarian Regimes Differ from One Another?

Authoritarian regimes sometimes can seem more different from one another than they are from democracies. As an extreme example, take two authoritarian regimes that have governed in southern Africa for the bulk of the last few decades (both in power at the time of writing): one in Zimbabwe and one in Botswana. The Zimbabwe African National Union–Patriotic Front (ZANU–PF) is currently in charge of the former, and the Botswana Democratic Party (BDP) is currently in charge of the latter. Yet, how politics worked in each of these regimes has been dramatically different. In Zimbabwe, Robert Mugabe was the regime's only leader from 1980 to 2017, and—even though he was 93 at the time of his overthrow—he showed little intention of ever stepping down prior. His wife, Grace Mugabe, stated in 2017, for example, that he should run "as a corpse" in the 2018 elections if he died before the vote. Power was concentrated in Mugabe's hands, human rights abuses were widespread, and Zimbabwe's corruption ranking was 154th (out of 176 countries), making it one of the most corrupt countries in the world. It is doubtful that much will change under his successor, Emmerson Mnangagwa. In Botswana, by contrast, Ian Khama is the regime's fourth leader and, due to term limits, likely to step down once his term expires. Substantial political power lies with the BDP, which can provide a check on the leadership. Botswana is the least corrupt country in Africa and one of the least corrupt countries in the world (with a ranking of 35). Moreover, though Botswana is considered authoritarian in this book because of evidence of unequal playing fields in its elections, a number of observers actually classify it as democratic. In other words, Botswana appears to have more in common with a democracy such as the one in Ghana than it does with an authoritarian regime such as the one that governs Zimbabwe.

As this comparison illustrates, authoritarian regimes can differ from one another in important ways and along a variety of fronts, including the institutions they rely on to maintain power, the extent to which they allow electoral competition, the constraints leaders face on their rule, how much they repress their populations, and how much they steal from the state, to name a few.

Why Is It Important to Differentiate Authoritarian Regimes from One Another?

Authoritarian regimes vary from one another in a number of ways, and differences across them are systematically tied to differences in their behavior. Disaggregating dictatorships, therefore, can reveal important distinctions in terms of how politics works in authoritarian contexts and, consequently, the types of political outcomes we are likely to see. These out-

comes include the extent to which authoritarian regimes rely on repression, their propensity for civil war, their vulnerabilities to economic sanctions, the risk they will collapse at any given moment, and their chances of democratization, to name a few.

This excerpt focuses on the chapter's categorical typology: disaggregating authoritarian regimes by the institution that constrains the leader and structures elite politics.

What Is the Regime Typology Emphasized in This Chapter and Why?

Much of this book discusses the ways in which the interactions of authoritarian actors influence how politics works. To inform the discussion, this chapter disaggregates authoritarian regimes according to their institutional structures, given that such structures shape the nature of these interactions. The specific typology this book relies on therefore differentiates authoritarian regimes based on the type of institution that constrains the leadership, whether it is a military (military dictatorship), single political party (dominant-party dictatorship), ruling family (monarchic dictatorship), or none of these (personalist dictatorship).

Note that because there have been so few monarchic dictatorships historically—there are only seven in power at the time of writing—it is difficult to make meaningful inferences about their behavior. The discussion will therefore focus on the other three types of authoritarian regimes.

What Is Military Dictatorship?

Military dictatorship is authoritarian rule in which the military as an institution is in control. Military officers hold power, select who will fill the leadership post, and make policy choices. These individuals collectively are often referred to as a junta; most are senior (as opposed to junior) officers. In military dictatorships, elites mostly come from the military, as does the de facto leader. Occasionally, such regimes place "puppets" in the leadership position to pay lip service to civilian rule even though these individuals, in fact, have little power. Panama from 1982 to 1989 is an example of this: General Manuel Noriega was the de facto leader of the regime, but a string of civilians officially served as the president.

The structure of military dictatorships usually reflects that of the military itself, such that the military's form is essentially transferred to the political sphere. Military dictatorships typically feature a clear, hierarchical organization of authority; some even have rules in place for rotating power. Critically, military elites are powerful enough in military dictatorships to constrain the actions of the leader.

Since World War II, military dictatorships have been particularly prevalent in Latin America, with the majority of the region's countries having at some point experienced this form of authoritarian rule. As one scholar wrote in 1999, "In no part of the developing world has the influence of the military been more profound than in Latin America. Political intervention and rule by the military have been almost the norm and not the regrettable exception." Part of the reason for this lies in Cold War geopolitics. Because of the region's close proximity to

the United States, the United States devoted substantial aid to Latin American militaries to ensure they were anti-Communist and, in some cases, directly assisted them in executing coups against democratically elected leaders, as occurred in Chile in 1973. Military dictatorships have also been common in sub-Saharan Africa, though to a lesser degree than in Latin America.

Examples of military dictatorship include Brazil (1964–1985), Ghana (1972–1979), and Turkey (1980–1983).

When a Leader Wears a Military Uniform, Does That Signal Military Dictatorship?

Many authoritarian leaders wear military uniforms. This tells us little, however, about whether the regime is a military dictatorship, as conceptualized here. The definition of military dictatorship referenced earlier emphasizes the military as an institution in government, not simply a single military officer. It implies as well that other members of the military can influence the leader's choices.

As examples, though Idi Amin of Uganda and Muammar Gaddafi of Libya both wore military uniforms, neither of their regimes was a military dictatorship. Under both rulers, power was concentrated in their hands and few other actors could challenge them, classic characteristics of personalist rule. By contrast, in the Brazilian military dictatorship, generals served a single presidential term, and in the latest Argentine military dictatorship (from 1976 to 1983), the junta implemented a rotating presidency among its members. Military officials held key positions of power in both regimes and the military elite was powerful enough to constrain the leadership.

While it is safe to assume that military dictatorship implies a man in uniform in the leadership post, the converse is not true. Some leaders who are current or former military officers govern military dictatorships, but many others do not.

What Is Dominant-Party Dictatorship?

Dominant-party dictatorship is an authoritarian regime in which a single political party controls leadership selection and policy. Members of the party hold the majority of key political posts, and regime elites typically come from the party's ruling body, often referred to as a politburo or central committee. The leader is usually the leader of the party as well. Though a single party controls the levers of power, other parties may legally exist in dominant-party dictatorships, and they may be allowed to contest elections and occasionally win them. Even when other parties hold a number of legislative seats, however, true political power lies with the dominant party. A relevant example is Singapore, where the 2015 legislative election gave 83 out of 89 seats to the People's Action Party, but 6 to the Worker's Party (an opposition party). The opposition has representation in the legislature, though power is tilted toward the ruling party.

With the exception of many of the Communist dominant-party dictatorships that gov-

erned during the Cold War, the structure of dominant-party dictatorships is often quite similar to the structure of democracies. Most are either presidential or parliamentary: if the regime uses a presidential system, then it mirrors a presidential democracy; the same is true if it is a parliamentary system. Importantly, party elites are powerful actors in dominant-party dictatorships and have the capacity to influence the actions of the leader.

Since World War II, dominant-party dictatorships have been particularly prevalent in Eastern Europe, parts of Africa, and Asia. Their distribution is explained by two factors. The first factor is Cold War geopolitics, with those countries falling under the Soviet Union's sphere of influence often adopting dominant-party systems of authoritarian rule. This is certainly the case for much of Eastern Europe, but also true of many dominant-party regimes in Asia. In the case of Africa, though the Soviet Union propped up a few of the dominant-party dictatorships there, more frequently they emerged on the heels of the independence movements that swept across the region in the decades that followed the end of World War II. In countries such as Namibia, Kenya, and Botswana, a political party led the independence effort and simply stayed in power afterward.

Examples of dominant-party dictatorship include Angola (1975–), Mexico (1915–2000), and Cote d'Ivoire (1960–1999).

Does the Existence of a Regime Support Party Signal Dominant-Party Dictatorship?

Most authoritarian regimes govern with the support of a political party. In fact, 91 percent of authoritarian regimes featured at least one political party in the post-World War II period at some point while in power. In more than half of these cases, however, the support party had little real political influence and, as such, these regimes are not dominant-party dictatorships. (Chapter 7 discusses the purposes of support parties.)

As an example, consider the fact that Saddam Hussein governed Iraq from 1979 to 2003, all the while in alliance with the Baath Party. Elites within the party could do little to guide Hussein's actions, instead serving to simply carry out his wishes. In a similar fashion, General Omar Torrijos and the military led Panama from 1968 to 1982. At first the regime banned political parties, but in 1978 it legalized them and created the Revolutionary Democratic Party (PRD) to organize its supporters. Yet, the PRD had little political weight and could not constrain Torrijos or help shape policy.

Because the vast majority of authoritarian regimes govern with the assistance of a support party, the existence of such parties should not be seen as an indicator of dominant-party rule. Categorizing a regime as such requires greater knowledge about the de facto power of the party's elite members. As a quick snapshot, however, the party elite are typically more powerful when the party organization predated the regime's assumption to power.

What Is Personalist Dictatorship?

Personalist dictatorships fit the classic stereotype of authoritarian rule. In personalist dictatorships, power lies in the hands of the leader. The leader controls access to key political posts, as well as most major policy decisions. The leader may wear a military uniform or govern with the support of a political party, but neither institution exercises power independently of the leader. In personalist dictatorships, elites typically are family members of the leader or loyal allies.

To be clear, in nearly all authoritarian regimes, leaders disproportionately wield political influence. In personalist dictatorships, however, this is extremely tilted, such that there are no political institutions that are autonomous. Leaders keep the elite on their toes, ensuring that no faction among them ever becomes too powerful. As one observer wrote regarding Mobutu Sese Seko in then Zaire, "Conventional wisdom in Kinshasa says that besides Mobutu and his family only 80 people in the country count. At any one time, 20 of them are ministers, 20 are exiles, 20 are in jail and 20 are ambassadors. Every three months, the music stops and Mobutu forces everyone to change chairs."

The structure of personalist dictatorships varies from one context to the next. It depends largely on the personal preferences of the leader. Leaders in personalist dictatorships may even change the structure of the regime over the course of their time in office.

Since the end of World War II, personalist dictatorships have dotted the landscape of much of the developing world and even parts of the developed world, as the experiences of Spain under Francisco Franco and Portugal under Antonio Oliveira Salazar illustrate. There is no single developing region that has escaped the emergence of personalist dictatorship, though sub-Saharan Africa has seen a larger proportion. This may be due to the fact that it is the poorest region in the developing world: because low levels of economic development are associated with weak institutions, such contexts may facilitate the emergence of personalist rule. It is difficult to disentangle, however, whether weak institutions cause personalist dictatorship or are themselves the product of it. Regardless, personalist dictatorships have tended to be more common where levels of economic development are low. With the emergence of personalist dictatorships in more advanced developing countries in recent years, however, such as Turkey, Russia, and Venezuela, this may be changing.

Examples of personalist dictatorship include Malawi under Hastings Banda (1964–1994), the Philippines under Ferdinand Marcos (1972–1986), and Haiti under the Duvaliers (1957–1986).

How Does Authoritarian Regime Type Influence Leaders' Fear of Punishment after Leaving Power?

A number of studies show that authoritarian leaders' expectations about their futures after leaving office influence their behaviors while in power, as discussed in Chapter 4. For the most part, fear of facing a bad fate is associated with quite a bit of bad behavior, including initiating conflict, ratcheting up repression, and clinging to power at all costs.

Authoritarian regimes exhibit systematic differences in terms of how their leaders fare after

leaving office. Specifically, in personalist dictatorships, most leaders encounter a bad fate upon their exit from power: 69 percent of personalist leaders are either exiled, imprisoned, or killed after ouster. These numbers are noticeably lower for leaders in other types of authoritarian regimes. Around half of all leaders in monarchic and military dictatorships suffer serious consequences upon leaving power. Leaders in dominant-party dictatorships fare the best, with only about a third (37 percent) facing exile, imprisonment, or death after their exits.

With the exception of military dictatorships, all these numbers are even worse if the leader's overthrow takes down the regime as well. The regime's collapse often signals that enemies of the leader are now in control, whereas its continuance typically means the leader's old allies are. The former should be more likely to try to punish the leader than the latter, and indeed that is what the data show. For this reason, bad fates are more likely when the regime collapses, too.

The evidence therefore suggests that one of the reasons why personalist dictatorships are associated with a host of negative outcomes (many of which will be discussed shortly) is the fact that their leaders are the most likely to fare poorly after leaving power.

What Are the Consequences of Authoritarian Regime Type for Political Outcomes?

Research indicates that authoritarian regimes differ systematically in their policy choices and behaviors. Many of these differences are between personalist dictatorships and other forms of authoritarianism (discussed in Chapter 4), largely because of the absence of checks on the leadership in personalist contexts. That said, occasionally, the differences also are between whether elites come from the military or a dominant party.

First, there is substantial evidence that foreign policy choices are different in personalist dictatorships than they are elsewhere. Among authoritarian regimes, personalist dictatorships are the most likely to initiate conflicts with other states. They are the most belligerent form of dictatorship because they can incite interstate disputes without fearing domestic repercussions should they lose them. Lack of accountability, in other words, leads to riskier behavior. Relatedly, though the well-known democratic peace theory suggests that democracies rarely fight one another, democracies do get into altercations with dictatorships, and these dictatorships are most likely to be personalist. The absence of domestic constraints also makes personalist dictatorships more likely than other forms of authoritarianism to invest in nuclear weapons, as examples of North Korea under the Kim family and Libya under Gaddafi illustrate. It also makes them less likely to engage in cooperative behavior internationally. Personalist dictatorships are the least likely of all dictatorships to sign international agreements, because their leaders have greater policy flexibility. This same concentration of power, however, makes personalist dictatorships the most vulnerable to collapse in the face of economic sanctions. Leaders in personalist dictatorships are more likely to rely on external sources of revenue to fund their patronage networks, thereby making them more susceptible to overthrow when subject to sanctions. Moreover, because leaders in personalist dictatorships often surround themselves with loyal sycophants to reduce their own risk

of ouster, they typically receive bad intelligence. They are therefore not only more likely to start wars, but also more likely to lose them. Leaders in personalist dictatorships intentionally encircle themselves with "yes men" and, consequently, are more likely to receive inaccurate information from their subordinates and make foreign policy errors.

Second, there is evidence that personalist dictatorships make different domestic policy choices than do other forms of authoritarianism. Not surprisingly, research shows that policies are more unstable in personalist dictatorships than elsewhere. Leaders can change policy on a whim because there are no other actors who need to weigh in on choices. As evidence of this, they see more volatile inflation from one year to the next than other dictatorships do; they are also better able to react quickly to exogenous price shocks. In addition, personalist dictatorships are the most likely of all authoritarian regimes to waste foreign aid. Rather than devoting aid toward political liberalization (which is usually its intended purpose), personalist dictatorships direct it toward their narrow group of supporters as a means of extending their hold on power. In other dictatorships, by contrast, leaders rely on larger support groups and, as a result, might anticipate that they have a reasonably good chance of remaining in office after democratization. They are therefore more likely to devote foreign aid to political liberalization, as envisioned. Relatedly, there is also some evidence that the absence of constraints in personalist dictatorships leads to lower levels of economic growth and investment than in other authoritarian regimes. There is evidence as well that they are the most prone to corruption. Because personalist dictatorships are rarely punished for abuses of power, they can engage in corrupt acts as a means of rewarding their small network of supporters.

Third, personalist dictatorships are less susceptible to regime collapse in response to typical threats to their rule than are other dictatorships. For example, personalist dictatorships are less vulnerable to overthrow in the face of economic crises than are other forms of authoritarianism: citizens may suffer when the regime's economy performs poorly, but not the small group of regime supporters. It often takes a full-fledged economic disaster for personalist regimes to encounter destabilizing challenges to their rule. For similar reasons, personalist dictatorships are more resilient to mass protests than are other forms of dictatorship.

Many important political outcomes differ based on whether an authoritarian regime is personalist or not. A number of others, however, depend on whether a dominant party rules the regime or some other group. There is evidence, for example, that dominant-party dictatorships are less repressive than are other forms of dictatorship. Because dominant-party governments are more likely to incorporate a sizable segment of the population into the political process, they are less likely to use repression as a means of influencing the population, instead exerting control through institutional channels. For somewhat similar reasons, dominant-party regimes also experience fewer civil wars than do other types of authoritarian regimes. Their tendency to include large groups of supporters in politics makes them more skilled at preventing grievances from escalating.

Importantly, there are very large differences in leader survival, regime survival, and democratization, based on whether the regime is military or not. Leaders in military dictatorships have far shorter tenures than do those who govern elsewhere: military dictators last around 4 years in office, on average, compared to other dictators, who last around 9 years. These

differences in leader longevity are largely due to the fact that the elite in military dictatorships have access to arms and the skills to use them. Should they wish to oust the leader, it is far easier to do so than in dictatorships, where the elite lack such resources.

Not only are military dictators more vulnerable to overthrow than are other authoritarian leaders, but so are their regimes. Military dictatorships are the shortest lived of all authoritarian regimes, while dominant-party dictatorships are the most long-lasting. Military dictatorships are also the most likely to democratize upon their collapse and personalist dictatorships are the least so. The reasons underlying these differences are explained in detail in Chapter 8.

To summarize, there are very real differences in political outcomes across authoritarian regimes that surface once they are disaggregated. Many of these differences are based on whether dictatorships are personalist or not, but a number of others have to do with whether there is a dominant party or military in government. Taken together, the evidence offered here suggests that lumping authoritarian regimes together into a single category risks obscuring significant differences in their behaviors. This is but one typology that illustrates this; others surely do as well.

What Type of Authoritarian Regime Is Most Common Today?

Figure 5.1 presents the number of authoritarian regimes in power from 1946 to 2010, broken down by regime type. It shows a number of interesting trends. The first is that monarchic dictatorships, which were always relatively rare, have remained so to this day. As of 2010, nearly all these regimes are in the Middle East, including those in Oman, Saudi Arabia, and the United Arab Emirates, with a notable exception being the monarchic dictatorship in Swaziland.

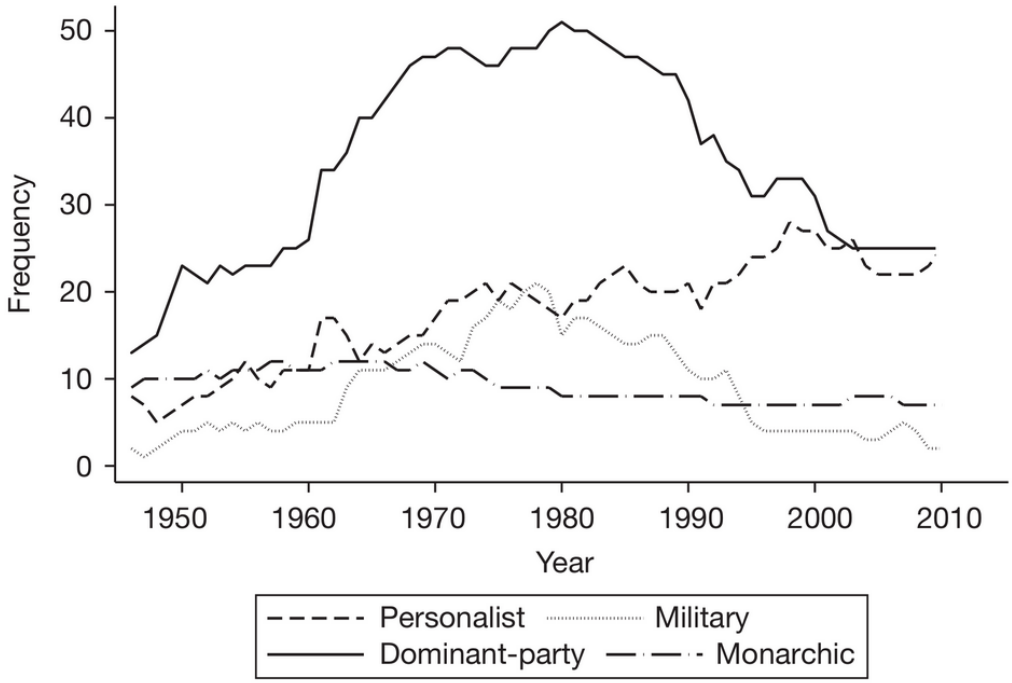

Figure 1: Figure 5.1 Number of authoritarian regimes in power, by type: 1946 to 2010.

Second, military dictatorships increased in number as the Cold War intensified, but have steadily decreased since. Much of the reason behind the rise of military dictatorships during the Cold War had to do with the United States and Soviet Union supporting these regimes to further their strategic interests at this time. The decline of military dictatorships that occurred subsequently can similarly be tied to both of these superpowers withdrawing their financial backing of these regimes as the Cold War came to its end. As of 2010, military dictatorships make up only a handful of the world's authoritarian regimes, including the regime in Myanmar, which at the time of writing may be in the process of negotiating a transition out of power.

Third, dominant-party dictatorships throughout the period have been the most common form of authoritarian regime. Like military dictatorships, they also rose and fell as the Cold War heated up and simmered. This is largely due to the spread and demise of Communist rule during this period, which lends itself to a dominant-party form of authoritarian governance. As of 2010, only a few Communist dominant-party dictatorships still remain in power, such as those in Laos, China, Cuba, and Vietnam. That said, even with the decline of Communism worldwide, there are more dominant-party dictatorships in office than any other form of authoritarian regime. Examples include the dominant-party regimes in Ethiopia, Singapore, Angola, and Tanzania.

Fourth, throughout the period, personalist dictatorships have steadily increased in number. From 2000 to 2010, they nearly equaled the number of dominant-party dictatorships in power. Should the rise of personalist dictatorship continue, they will become the most common form of authoritarian regime. Examples of contemporary personalist dictatorships include Belarus under Alexander Lukashenko, Uganda under Yoweri Museveni, Chad under

Idriss Deby, and Azerbaijan under Ilham Aliyev.

It is difficult to assess why personalist dictatorship is becoming a more frequent form of authoritarian rule. The end of the Cold War can account for some of the decline in dominant-party rule and much of the decline in military rule. The ideology-based regimes of the Cold War (with the Communists on the left and the military juntas primarily on the right) experienced a number of policy failures and were therefore discredited, perhaps paving the way for post-ideological authoritarianism, which is particularly compatible with personalist rule. It is also possible that the emphasis on mimicking democracy—*en vogue* in the post-Cold War period—is easily accomplished with personalist dictatorship.

Regardless of the "whys" behind the rise of personalist dictatorship, all signs indicate it is set to continue. Though systematic codings of regime type only go through 2010, many of the new authoritarian regimes that have come to power since appear to be personalist. Examples include the brief dictatorships in Afghanistan under Hamid Karzai from 2010 to 2014, Ukraine under Viktor Yanukovych from 2012 to 2014, and Sri Lanka under Mahinda Rajapaksa from 2010 to 2015, as well as a few dictatorships still in power at the time of writing, such as the regime of Pierre Nkurunziza in Burundi that began in 2010 upon his consolidation of power around the time of that year's election, that of Salva Kiir Mayardit in South Sudan that began after that country's independence in 2011, and that of Recep Erdogan in Turkey that solidified following his crackdown on the opposition after 2016's failed coup. It is true that not all new dictatorships that have emerged since the start of 2010 fit the strongman mold, such as the military dictatorships in Thailand (which assumed power in 2014 and is still in office at the time of writing) and Mali (in power from 2012 to 2014), but a sizable proportion of them seem personalist in nature. (See Chapter 4 for a discussion of the indicators of personalization—the process of movement toward one-man rule—and some of its political consequences.)

Moreover, many of the world's democracies on the brink of transitioning to dictatorship feature a strongman leader, such as Daniel Ortega of Nicaragua, Rodrigo Duterte of the Philippines, and Viktor Orban of Hungary. I cannot say for certain whether the rise in personalist dictatorship is set to continue in the years to come, but all signs are pointing in that direction.